

# Founder Operating Contract

Keep market signal strong. Remove routine founder dependency.

This is a proposed working agreement for discovery. It is not a claim about the confidential firm's current executive model.

|                                                                                   |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Market and positioning                                                            |
| <b>FOUNDER OWNS</b><br>External narrative, strategic relationships, market signal |
| <b>COO OWNS</b><br>Operational implications, capacity and economics               |
| <b>JOINT / THRESHOLD</b><br>Material positioning changes                          |

|                                                                            |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Client commitments                                                         |
| <b>FOUNDER OWNS</b><br>Executive relationship and exceptional deal shaping |
| <b>COO OWNS</b><br>Handoff quality, scope, staffing, delivery and proof    |
| <b>JOINT / THRESHOLD</b><br>Nonstandard risk / strategic logo              |

|                                                                               |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| People and bench                                                              |
| <b>FOUNDER OWNS</b><br>Executive-caliber network and cultural signal          |
| <b>COO OWNS</b><br>Org design, managers, hiring plan, onboarding, performance |
| <b>JOINT / THRESHOLD</b><br>Executive hires and material structure changes    |

|                                                                                         |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| AI systems                                                                              |
| <b>FOUNDER OWNS</b><br>External differentiation and major capability bets               |
| <b>COO OWNS</b><br>Agent jobs, owners, evals, cost, escalation, release and improvement |
| <b>JOINT / THRESHOLD</b><br>Client-facing autonomy / material risk                      |

|                                                                             |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Financial operations                                                        |
| <b>FOUNDER OWNS</b><br>Capital posture and owner-level risk appetite        |
| <b>COO OWNS</b><br>Forecast, P&L rhythm, margin, billing, cash, utilization |
| <b>JOINT / THRESHOLD</b><br>Threshold exceptions / investment decisions     |

# Founder Operating Contract

Cadence, attention budget, and performance

Draft for discovery

## Standing leadership sync

**Purpose:** close decisions that cross market, client, operating, and capital boundaries - not replay departmental updates.

- Market signal and strategic relationships
- Client/portfolio exceptions above threshold
- Forecast, margin, cash, and capacity posture
- People / organization decisions
- AI capability and risk decisions
- Explicit decisions, owners, dates, and communication

## Founder attention budget

Track founder involvement as a scarce strategic resource. Every recurring escalation is classified:

- **Value creating:** market access, strategic relationship, differentiated judgment
- **Temporary:** new mechanism still stabilizing
- **Structural defect:** missing owner, decision right, information, capability, or confidence
- **Retire:** routine work that should no longer route through the founder

|                                                                                               |                                                                                                      |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Clients</b> retention, outcome evidence, escalation quality                                | <b>Economics</b> margin integrity, forecast credibility, cash discipline                             |
| <b>Delivery</b> Schedule, scope, quality, adoption, reuse of learning                         | <b>Team</b> Manager strength, bench readiness, onboarding speed, async discipline                    |
| <b>AI capacity</b> reliability, owner confidence, cost, human override, quarterly improvement | <b>Founder leverage</b> fewer routine dependencies without loss of market signal or decision quality |

**Calibrated question:** What would make it safe for the founder to miss the weekly operating review for a month - and still trust the company is carrying the promise?